

Donald Metzler

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Summary

Research scientist working on large language models: pretraining, evaluation, and how models store and retrieve knowledge. Co-author of *Emergent Abilities of Large Language Models* and of UL2, Ext5, and Charforme, and of the work that helped establish generative retrieval as a research area. ACM SIGIR Academy inductee and ACM Distinguished Member with three Test of Time awards. Author or co-author of two books and over 100 publications with 35,000+ citations (h-index 61), and inventor on 14 issued US patents.

Employment

- **Google (2012 - Present)**, *Senior Staff Research Scientist*
 - **Google Research / Google DeepMind** (2019 - Present) - Research on large language model foundations, currently focused on pre-training data quality for Gemini. Work in the group has spanned AI-generated text and code detection, freshness and temporal reasoning, reinforcement learning scaling, agents, and generative information retrieval. Tech Lead and Manager for teams of up to ~30 engineers and research scientists. Contributed to major launches across Gemini, Gemini App, Search, Cloud, and Chrome.
 - **G Suite / Google Apps** (2014 - 2019) - Led a team of ~40 to improve search and finding across G Suite. Led over 100 launches, significantly improving Gmail and Drive search quality.
 - **Display Ads** (2012 - 2014) - Tech Lead for Rephil, a large-scale topic modeling system. Developed methods for incremental model updates, yielding quality and revenue gains.
- **Chomp (2011 - 2012)**, *Technology Advisor*
- **University of Southern California (2010 - 2012)**, *Research Assistant Professor, Department of Computer Science; Computer Scientist, Information Sciences Institute*
- **Yahoo! (2007 - 2010)**, *Senior Research Scientist*
- **Microsoft (2006)**, *Research Intern*

Education

- **Ph.D., Computer Science**, September 2007, University of Massachusetts, Amherst, MA
- **M.S., Computer Science**, May 2005, University of Massachusetts, Amherst, MA
- **B.S., Computer Science and Mathematics**, Summa Cum Laude, May 2002, Rose-Hulman Institute of Technology, Terre Haute, IN

Awards and Honors

- **Inductee**, ACM SIGIR Academy, 2025
- **Distinguished Member**, ACM, 2021
- **Test of Time Awards**: SIGIR 2026, CIKM 2021, ECIR 2017
- **Test of Time Honorable Mentions**: SIGIR 2023, SIGIR 2017
- **Best Paper Awards and Honorable Mentions**: WSDM 2021, WSDM 2017, WSDM 2012, SIGIR 2011, CIKM 2010, SIGIR 2005

Publications and Patents

- **Books**: Author of "*A Feature-Centric View of Information Retrieval*" (Springer, 2011); co-author of "*Search Engines: Information Retrieval in Practice*" (Addison Wesley, 2009)
- **Impact**: Over 100 publications with 35,000+ citations and an h-index of 61. See my Scholar profile for full details.
- **Journal Articles**: Published in TMLR, ACM Computing Surveys, SIGIR Forum, Foundations and Trends in Information Retrieval, and more.
- **Conference Papers**: Extensive publications in top-tier conferences including NAACL, EMNLP, ACL, ICML, SIGIR, NeurIPS, ICLR, and WSDM.
- **Patents**: 14 issued US patents in areas including attention architectures, efficient decoding, search result ranking, match-making systems, and query expansion.

Professional Activities

- **Program Chair**: WSDM 2014, ICTIR 2013, OAIR/RIAO 2013. **Awards Chair**: SIGIR 2025.
- **Selection Committee**, ACM SIGIR Academy, 2026-2027.
- **Editorial boards**: ACM Transactions on Information Systems (TOIS), ACM Transactions on the Web (TWEB), Information Retrieval Journal.
- **Area chair / senior PC member**: NeurIPS, ICLR, ICML, EMNLP, SIGIR, WSDM, CIKM, ECIR, and others.
- **Organized**: Gen-IR workshops at SIGIR 2023 and 2024; tutorials at SIGIR, WSDM, and WWW.
- **Reviewer** for 15+ journals; NSF panelist and European Research Council reviewer.

Research Grants

- Key Personnel, DARPA, "*Situational Awareness for Social Media: Theories, Models and Algorithms*," \$6,206,500, 2012-2015
- PI, NSF EAGER, "*Constructing, Indexing, and Searching Super-Enriched Document Representations in the Cloud*," \$250,000, 2011-2013

- PI, NSF EAGER, "*Automatically Building Test Collections Using Implicit Relevance Signals from the Web*," \$150,000, 2011-2012